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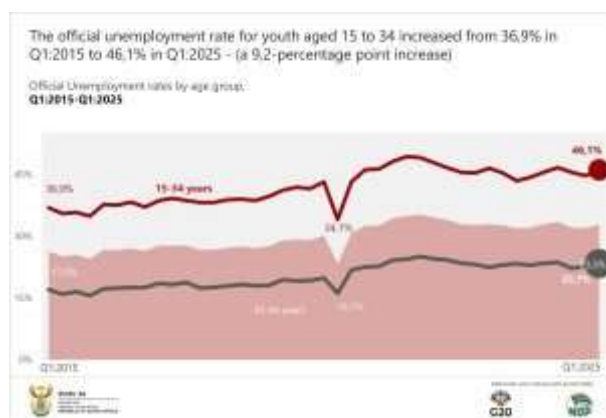
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- South Africa's Youth in the Labour Market: A Decade in Review

[South Africa's Youth in the Labour Market: A Decade in Review](#)

According to the latest Quarterly Labour Force Survey (QLFS) released by Statistics South Africa (Stats SA) for Q1:2025, young people aged 15 to 34 make up roughly 50,2% of South Africa's working-age population, translating to approximately 20,9 million individuals. Within this cohort, the 15-24 age group— representing around 10,3 million individuals— faces the highest barriers to entering the workforce, with unemployment figures significantly outpacing that of older youth.

The challenges facing young South Africans in the employment space are not new, but they are trending negatively in many cases. Over the past ten years, youth unemployment has remained persistently high.

In the first quarter of 2015, the official unemployment rate for youth aged 15 to 34 was 36,9%. By Q1:2025, that figure had climbed to 46,1%— a 9,2 percentage point increase that highlights deteriorating prospects for millions.



The situation is even more pronounced among the youngest jobseekers:

For youth aged 15 to 24, unemployment stood at 50,3% in Q1:2015. A decade later, it has risen to 62,4%. Among those aged 25 to 34, the rate increased from 31,4% to 40,4% over the same period.

Uneven Ground: Youth in Non-Urban Areas Bear the Brunt of Unemployment

Youth unemployment remains one of South Africa's most pressing challenges— but its weight falls unevenly across the country. In the North West and the Eastern Cape provinces, the plight of unemployed youth deepens into economic exclusion. The first quarter of 2025 saw North West record a youth unemployment rate of 58,8%, while only 43,0% of its young people aged 15-34 were active in the labour market. In the Eastern Cape, the picture is similarly serious. With an unemployment rate of 54,3% and the lowest youth labour force participation rate nationally at 39,8%, fewer than four in ten young people are either employed or looking for work.

A Double Burden: Young, Female, and Locked Out of the Economy

The youth labour market not only reflects age-based disparities but also entrenched gender inequalities. Women continue to face greater barriers to employment, particularly among the youth. In Q1:2025, the NEET (Not in Employment, Education or Training) rate for young people aged 15-24 stood at 37,1%, with young women (37,5%) slightly more affected than young men (36,7%). However, the disparity widens in the broader 15-34 age group, where the NEET rate was recorded at 45,1%. Within this cohort, 48,1% of women were NEET, compared to 42,2% of men, highlighting a persistent gender gap in access to work and skills development.

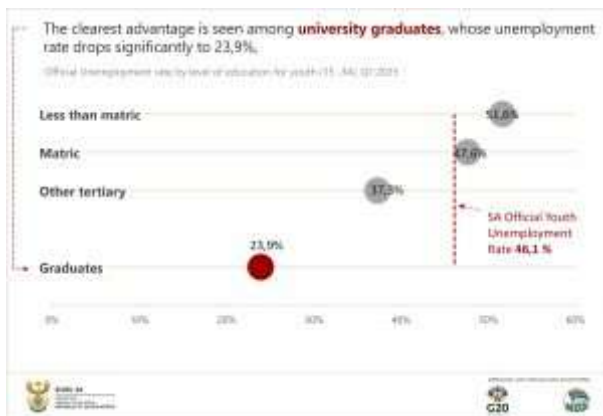
Discouragement and the Elusive First Job

For many young South Africans, landing a job is more than just a milestone— it is a crucial step toward economic independence and inclusion. Yet for millions, this first step remains out of reach. In the first quarter of 2025 approximately 1,9 million youth aged 15-34 were classified as discouraged work-seekers (persons who have given up looking for work), compared to 1,5 million adults aged 35-64. The figures reveal how young people are especially vulnerable to discouragement, driven by limited experience and fewer employment opportunities.

Among the 4,8 million unemployed youth in Q1:2025, 58,7% reported having no previous work experience. That means nearly six in ten unemployed young people are still waiting for their first opportunity to enter the job market. Without experience, youth struggle to get hired— yet without being hired, they cannot gain experience. This cycle of exclusion continues to fuel long-term unemployment and stalls skills development at a critical stage of life.

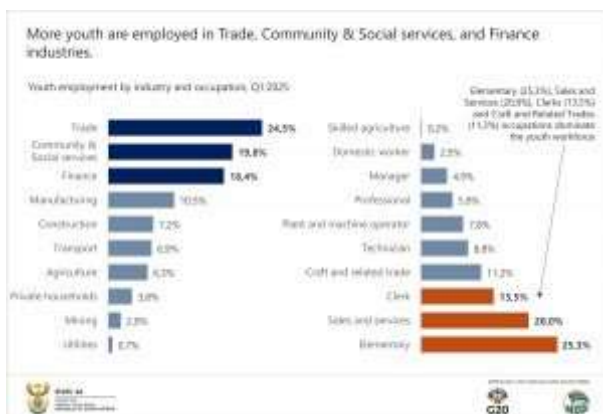
The Education Divide: How Qualifications Shape Employment Outcomes

Education continues to play a pivotal role in determining young people's employment prospects. Those without a matric qualification face the steepest uphill climb, with an unemployment rate of 51,6%— the highest across all education levels. For those who complete matric, the situation improves marginally, though the unemployment rate remains high at 47,6%. Youth who obtain vocational or technical training (classified as "Other Tertiary") fare somewhat better, with the unemployment rate reduced to 37,3%. The clearest advantage is seen among university graduates, whose unemployment rate drops significantly to 23,9%, illustrating the protective effect of higher education in a tight labour market.



Where Are the Jobs? Youth Employment by Industry and Role

Despite the challenges, certain industries continue to provide key opportunities for young workers. In Q1:2025, the Trade industry— including retail, wholesale, and hospitality— remained the largest employer of youth, absorbing 24,5% of the employed youth population. This was followed by Community and Social Services (19,8%), Finance (18,4%), and Manufacturing (10,5%).



When it comes to job roles, youth are most concentrated in Elementary occupations (25,3%), Sales and Services (20,0%), Clerical roles (13,5%), and Craft and Related Trades (11,2%). These numbers paint a clear picture: many young workers are clustered in low-skilled, or service-based occupations.

For more information, download the Quarterly Labour Force Survey (QLFS) for Q1:2025 [here](#).

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